Book Project Memo

October–December 2026

A conversation starter for Alfredo Mathew III and Selim Jamil

Purpose

This memo proposes a three-month engagement to explore whether Alfredo and Selim can develop a meaningful book project through dialogue.

The project is not a ghostwriting arrangement. Alfredo remains the author of his own ideas and writing. Selim is a thought partner, listener, questioner, researcher, and independent contributor. The work should preserve both voices and make the collaboration visible.

The immediate goal is not to finish a book. It is to create enough clarity, material, and momentum to determine what kind of book, if any, should emerge from the conversation.

What does "publishing a book" mean in 2026?

Publishing no longer describes only one path. It can mean creating a finished work, making it publicly available, distributing it through book channels, or asking a publisher to invest in and represent it. Those are related but different decisions.

For this project, possible forms include:

- Traditional publishing: An agent or author sells publishing rights to a trade publisher, usually in exchange for an advance and royalties. The publisher typically provides editorial, production, and distribution support, while the contract determines what rights are licensed and for how long.
- Independent or university press: A smaller or specialized publisher evaluates the work for a particular intellectual, educational, or cultural audience and develops it through a more focused editorial relationship.
- Self-publishing: Alfredo retains control, hires or coordinates the needed services, and releases the book through platforms such as Amazon KDP or IngramSpark. KDP supports ebooks, paperbacks, and hardcovers; IngramSpark supports print-on-demand and broader distribution.
- Assisted or hybrid publishing: An author pays a service provider for some combination of editing, design, production, marketing, and distribution. The contract must be examined carefully because the author may carry substantial costs while giving up rights or receiving less support than expected.
- Digital or limited publication: The work can begin as a website, serialized correspondence, designed PDF, small private edition, or print-on-demand prototype. This can create a public record, invite readers, and test the work before a larger publishing decision.

An ISBN identifies a particular edition and format; it is useful for booksellers, libraries, and distribution, but it is not the same thing as editorial validation or cultural impact. A published book can therefore be a public prototype, an independent edition, a traditionally acquired manuscript, or a series of connected forms.

The three-month project should discover which form serves the work rather than deciding in advance that publication must mean a traditional deal.

Five working ideas

1. Begin with the relationship and the method

The work will happen through conversation. Selim will listen deeply, ask questions, offer his own thinking, and respond to what Alfredo is trying to understand. Alfredo will write, speak, test ideas, and decide what belongs to his work.

The process should be flexible enough to accommodate family, health, caregiving, work, and the precariousness of life. The relationship matters as much as the schedule.

2. Identify the central questions

During October, they will identify the questions strong enough to organize a book. Possible lines of inquiry include:

- What does economic democracy mean in practical life?
- Why does ownership matter to ordinary workers and families?
- How should public education, civic learning, and wealth building relate to one another?
- What could universal asset building look like from birth through school and adulthood?
- How do Alfredo's family history, his father's public life, and his own work shape these ideas?
- What can teachers, parents, students, institutions, and communities do with them?

The point is not to cover everything Alfredo has thought about. It is to discover which questions generate energy, clarity, and a possible reader.

3. Treat the correspondence as primary material

The written correspondence is not merely preparation for a book. It may itself become part of the book's form.

Each exchange should be preserved, lightly organized, and dated. Alfredo's reflections, Selim's questions, Selim's independent insights, and later editorial notes should remain distinguishable. The project can test whether the back-and-forth is more compelling and honest than a conventional single-author manuscript.

Possible forms include a book of correspondence and reflection; a conversation that leads into Alfredo's essays; an Alfredo-authored book with Selim's questions included; or a short first book that introduces Alfredo's larger body of work.

4. Produce a small, serious prototype

By December, the project should produce more than conversations and less than a forced manuscript: a book-shaped prototype that allows both collaborators to judge the work.

It might include an opening statement, three to five organized sections, selected correspondence, Alfredo's fuller reflections, Selim's original contributions, and a brief note about audience, authorship, collaboration, and the role of other voices.

The prototype is a test of the work, not a promise that the final book will take that exact form.

5. End with a decision, not an obligation

At the end of December, they should decide what they have learned. They may continue toward a book together, make the correspondence the central form, have Alfredo write with Selim as a continuing thought partner, develop a shorter first book, pause while preserving the work, or conclude that the dialogue is valuable even if it does not become a book.

Publishing is a possible outcome, but publication alone is not the measure of success. The work should create something useful, honest, and alive.

Three-month milestones

October - Establish the inquiry

- Confirm the working relationship: thought partnership, not ghostwriting.
- Agree on a practical rhythm for calls, writing, and review.
- Review the existing correspondence, Alfredo's selected writings, and relevant family and public materials.
- Identify the central questions and likely reader or readers.
- Create a working map of possible sections and recurring themes.
- Produce an initial conversation packet: questions, source materials, and a first proposed structure.

October milestone: A shared inquiry map and a clear understanding of how the collaboration will work.

November - Deepen and test the material

- Hold focused conversations around the strongest questions.
- Develop at least three substantial sections or exchanges.
- Distinguish Alfredo's writing, Selim's writing, and the collaborative movement between them.
- Test whether the correspondence itself carries enough energy to be part of the book.
- Identify what is missing: evidence, explanation, personal history, research, or practical examples.
- Review the emerging material and make a first decision about form.

November milestone: A meaningful draft core - enough material to see the book's voice, audience, and possible architecture.

December - Assemble and decide

- Organize the strongest material into a coherent prototype.
- Write or select an opening that explains why the project matters.
- Complete three to five sections that can be read as a beginning book, not merely notes.
- Prepare a short project description, authorship statement, and proposed next step.
- Review the prototype together and, if useful, share it with one or two trusted readers.
- Decide whether and how to continue in 2027.

December milestone: A book-shaped prototype and a shared decision about the next phase.

Proposed outcome

At the end of the three months, Alfredo and Selim will have:

1. A clearer understanding of the questions Alfredo is trying to answer.
2. A documented body of dialogue that preserves both voices.
3. A prototype showing whether the conversation can become a compelling book.
4. A provisional audience, structure, authorship model, and publishing path.
5. A grounded decision about whether to continue, revise the form, pause, or stop.

The most important outcome is not simply a manuscript. It is a way of working together that honors Alfredo's authorship, Selim's original contribution, the intelligence of dialogue, and the realities of both men's lives.

Questions for discussion

- Does this feel like the right scale for October through December?
- What would make the engagement worthwhile even if it does not produce a finished book?
- Which questions feel most alive right now?
- What should remain private, and what might belong in a public work?
- How should credit and authorship be represented?
- What would we need to see by December to feel that the project is genuinely moving forward?